

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Issue-Based Prompt Scoping - Essay Practice Solutions

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Issue-Based Prompt Scoping - Essay Practice Solutions

Separate solutions for the question-only practice workbook. These are repository-authored models, not official UPSC model answers.

SOLUTION 1 - 2018-A1 Essay

Question

Alternative technologies for a climate change resilient India.

Verification status

Exact V1 wording from the local official paper; used to scope object, qualifier and India boundary.

Prompt reading and central thesis

Working thesis: Alternative technologies can strengthen India's climate resilience when they are locally appropriate, affordable and integrated with institutions and community knowledge; technology is an enabler of adaptation, not a substitute for ecological planning or social justice.

Method controls: Integrate Directive or demand, Object, Qualifier, Geography while remaining open to qualification, counter-reading and limits. This is a repository-authored model, not an official UPSC answer or compulsory formula.

Complete brainstorming and argument map

1. **Directive or demand:** Identify whether the wording asks a question, presents alternatives, asserts causation or makes a value judgment; that demand governs the essay's argumentative burden.
2. **Object:** The object is the precise phenomenon or relationship being examined, not the entire GS subject area surrounding it.
3. **Qualifier:** Words such as Indian, majority, youth, real, complex, alternative or better narrow the claim and must survive in the thesis.
4. **Geography:** State whether the prompt is bounded to India, South Asia, another named region or a wider frame; do not globalise or nationalise it automatically.
5. **Scale:** Locate the demand at individual, community, institutional, state, regional or global scale before importing examples from another level.
6. **Evaluative demand:** Where the prompt uses judgment terms such as threat, anomaly, myth, reality or complex, define the standard by which the judgment will be assessed.
7. **Excluded material:** Write a negative boundary naming adjacent content that will not enter unless it directly advances the exact prompt.
8. **Thesis boundary:** The thesis must answer the prompt's exact causal or evaluative claim with stated conditions, not announce that the issue has both advantages and disadvantages.

Suggested essay architecture

1. Open by restating the proposition in plain language without invented attribution.
2. Define the operative terms and state a qualified thesis.
3. Develop each distinct claim through mechanism, evidence and analysis.
4. Introduce the strongest counter-view or limiting condition.
5. Synthesize the competing insights instead of ending with a catalogue.
6. Conclude by returning to the proposition at a deeper level.

Model solution

Introduction. “Alternative technologies for a climate change resilient India.” is best approached as a proposition to be interpreted and defended, not as a cue for unrelated factual display. Alternative technologies can strengthen India's climate resilience when they are locally appropriate, affordable and integrated with institutions and community knowledge; technology is an enabler of adaptation, not a substitute for ecological planning or social justice.

Resilient agriculture. Drought-tolerant crops, micro-irrigation, soil monitoring and weather advisories can reduce climate-sensitive farm losses.

Distributed energy. Decentralised renewable systems and storage can support essential services when central networks fail.

Water security. Wastewater reuse, aquifer monitoring, rainwater harvesting and efficient treatment expand local buffers.

Risk information. Remote sensing, forecasting and last-mile warning systems improve preparedness only when alerts are trusted and actionable.

Climate-resilient settlements. Cool roofs, passive design, permeable surfaces and nature-based drainage can reduce heat and flood exposure.

Justice and capability. Open standards, local repair skills, finance and public procurement determine whether vulnerable communities can use the technology.

Counter-view and qualification. Expensive imported systems, energy-intensive solutions and poorly governed infrastructure can create new dependencies or shift risk elsewhere.

Conclusion. India needs not a catalogue of futuristic devices but a resilient technology ecosystem joining science, local institutions, ecological wisdom and equitable access.

SOLUTION 2 - 2019-B7 Essay

Question

Biased media is a real threat to Indian democracy.

Verification status

Exact V1 wording; used to expose the evaluative standards behind real threat and Indian democracy.

Prompt reading and central thesis

Working thesis: Biased media threatens Indian democracy when systematic distortion deprives citizens of reliable information, weakens scrutiny and polarises public reason, although viewpoint diversity must be protected and bias distinguished from mere disagreement.

Method controls: Integrate Directive or demand, Object, Qualifier, Geography while remaining open to qualification, counter-reading and limits. This is a repository-authored model, not an official UPSC answer or compulsory formula.

Complete brainstorming and argument map

1. **Directive or demand:** Identify whether the wording asks a question, presents alternatives, asserts causation or makes a value judgment; that demand governs the essay's argumentative burden.
2. **Object:** The object is the precise phenomenon or relationship being examined, not the entire GS subject area surrounding it.
3. **Qualifier:** Words such as Indian, majority, youth, real, complex, alternative or better narrow the claim and must survive in the thesis.
4. **Geography:** State whether the prompt is bounded to India, South Asia, another named region or a wider frame; do not globalise or nationalise it automatically.
5. **Evaluative demand:** Where the prompt uses judgment terms such as threat, anomaly, myth, reality or complex, define the standard by which the judgment will be assessed.

6. **Hidden tension:** Issue prompts normally contain a trade-off or double effect that must be made explicit, such as connection versus isolation or automation versus reskilling.
7. **Thesis boundary:** The thesis must answer the prompt's exact causal or evaluative claim with stated conditions, not announce that the issue has both advantages and disadvantages.
8. **Counter-case:** The strongest rival or beneficial effect should be stated fairly and used to qualify the thesis rather than appended as token balance.

Suggested essay architecture

1. Open by restating the proposition in plain language without invented attribution.
2. Define the operative terms and state a qualified thesis.
3. Develop each distinct claim through mechanism, evidence and analysis.
4. Introduce the strongest counter-view or limiting condition.
5. Synthesize the competing insights instead of ending with a catalogue.
6. Conclude by returning to the proposition at a deeper level.

Model solution

Introduction. "Biased media is a real threat to Indian democracy." is best approached as a proposition to be interpreted and defended, not as a cue for unrelated factual display. Biased media threatens Indian democracy when systematic distortion deprives citizens of reliable information, weakens scrutiny and polarises public reason, although viewpoint diversity must be protected and bias distinguished from mere disagreement.

Informed citizenship. Elections are meaningful only when citizens can evaluate competing claims through sufficiently reliable information.

Accountability. Selective silence or partisan framing can shield power and make public institutions less answerable.

Polarisation. Sensational and identity-driven coverage can replace deliberation with permanent mobilisation against imagined enemies.

Ownership and incentives. Concentrated ownership, advertising dependence and attention metrics can shape editorial priorities without explicit censorship.

Digital amplification. Algorithmic distribution and misinformation accelerate biased narratives and blur the boundary between journalism and propaganda.

Democratic safeguards. Independent regulation, transparency, media literacy, plural ownership and strong public-interest journalism must coexist with free expression.

Counter-view and qualification. Government control in the name of neutrality can itself become a greater democratic threat, and complete value-neutrality is neither possible nor desirable.

Conclusion. The democratic objective is not a voicelessly neutral press but a plural, transparent and accountable media order in which facts remain contestable without becoming disposable.

SOLUTION 3 - 2024-B5 Essay

Question

Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth precipitating depression and loneliness.

Verification status

Exact V1 wording, including the missing comma before precipitating; used for a causal-chain scoping application.

Prompt reading and central thesis

Working thesis: Social media can intensify FOMO by turning social comparison into a continuous, quantified and commercially amplified experience, yet youth distress arises from the interaction of platform design, social conditions and individual vulnerability rather than technology alone.

Method controls: Integrate Object, Qualifier, Actor, Causal demand while remaining open to qualification, counter-reading and limits. This is a repository-authored model, not an official UPSC answer or compulsory formula.

Complete brainstorming and argument map

1. **Object:** The object is the precise phenomenon or relationship being examined, not the entire GS subject area surrounding it.
2. **Qualifier:** Words such as Indian, majority, youth, real, complex, alternative or better narrow the claim and must survive in the thesis.
3. **Actor:** Identify who acts, experiences, decides, benefits or bears cost, and do not treat a broad group such as youth or farmers as homogeneous.
4. **Causal demand:** Where the prompt asserts causation, test each link through mechanism, evidence, mediator and limit instead of merely repeating the causal words.
5. **Hidden tension:** Issue prompts normally contain a trade-off or double effect that must be made explicit, such as connection versus isolation or automation versus reskilling.
6. **Thesis boundary:** The thesis must answer the prompt's exact causal or evaluative claim with stated conditions, not announce that the issue has both advantages and disadvantages.
7. **Counter-case:** The strongest rival or beneficial effect should be stated fairly and used to qualify the thesis rather than appended as token balance.
8. **Synthesis:** A good issue essay resolves the tension by distributing responsibility, specifying conditions and connecting feasible institutional action with agency and values.

Suggested essay architecture

1. Open by restating the proposition in plain language without invented attribution.
2. Define the operative terms and state a qualified thesis.
3. Develop each distinct claim through mechanism, evidence and analysis.
4. Introduce the strongest counter-view or limiting condition.
5. Synthesize the competing insights instead of ending with a catalogue.
6. Conclude by returning to the proposition at a deeper level.

Model solution

Introduction. "Social media is triggering 'Fear of Missing Out' amongst the youth precipitating depression and loneliness." is best approached as a proposition to be interpreted and defended, not as a cue for unrelated factual display. Social media can intensify FOMO by turning social comparison into a continuous, quantified and commercially amplified experience, yet youth distress arises from the interaction of platform design, social conditions and individual vulnerability rather than technology alone.

Comparison architecture. Curated highlights make ordinary life appear deficient and convert belonging into a visible competition for attention.

Attention economy. Notifications, streaks and algorithmic recommendation reward repeated checking and make absence feel like social loss.

Loneliness paradox. High connectivity can coexist with weak intimacy when interaction is performative, fragmented or measured through public approval.

Unequal vulnerability. Adolescents facing exclusion, academic pressure or weak support systems may experience the same platforms more harmfully.

Positive capability. Online communities can also provide expression, learning and support, especially where offline opportunities are limited.

Shared responsibility. Digital literacy, humane platform design, family communication, counselling and accessible mental-health services must work together.

Counter-view and qualification. Blaming social media alone ignores family stress, unemployment, educational pressure and pre-existing mental-health conditions.

Conclusion. The answer is neither digital abstinence nor technological fatalism, but an online environment in which connection serves human relationships instead of converting them into an endless status contest.